The Last Spin

By Evan Hunter

The boy sitting opposite him was his enemy, Tigo, and he wore a green silk jacket with an orange stripe on each sleeve. The jacket shrieked, "Enemy, enemy!"

"I got no bad blood for you. This is how the club said we should settle it. Without a big street diddlebop, you dig? I just happened to be picked for this, you know? You got to admit your boys shouldn't have come in our territory last night. One of us and. . . and one of you. Fair and square. But I want you to know I don't know you from a hole in the wall-except you wear a blue and gold jacket."

"And you wear a green and orange one," Danny said, "and that's enough for me."

Tigo picked up the gun, and then he took one of the cartridges from the table top. He broke open the gun, slid the cartridge into the cylinder, and then snapped the gun shut and twirled the cylinder. "Round

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and round she goes," he said, "and where she stops, nobody knows. There's six chambers in the cylinder and only one cartridge. That makes the odds five-to-one that the cartridge'll be in firing position when the cylinder stops whirling. You dig?"

Tigo stopped talking. The cylinder was stopped now. He took a deep breath, put the barrel of the .38 to his temple, and then squeezed the trigger.

The firing pin clicked on an empty chamber.

"Well, that was easy, wasn't it?" he asked. He shoved the gun across the table. "Your turn, Danny."

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INTRODUCTION

Two rival gangs decide to solve a problem one on one instead of making war on the streets. A gang member is chosen from each gang to play Russian roulette: one person must die. As the two young men face each other "playing" this game in an empty basement room. As they talk, they realize that they have much in common, neither is the enemy, and there is no reason to create an enemy out of either group. The young men decide to defy gang rules and meet on Sunday to hang out. Lesson learned, barrel spins, gun fires, one dies. Last Spin by Evan Hunter

Danny reached for the gun. It was cold in the basement room, but he was sweating now. He pulled the gun toward him, then left it on the table while he dried his palms on his trousers. He picked up the gun then and stared at it.

Danny slapped the cylinder with his left hand. The cylinder whirled, whirled, and then stopped. Slowly, Danny put the gun to his head. He wanted to close his eyes, but he didn't dare. Tigo, the enemy, was watching him. He returned Tigo's stare, and then he squeezed the trigger.

His heart skipped a beat, and then over the roar of his blood he heard the empty click. Hastily, he put the gun down on the table.

"Makes you sweat, don't it?" Tigo said.

Danny nodded, saying nothing. He watched Tigo. Tigo was looking at the gun.

"Me now, huh?" Tigo said. He took a deep breath, then picked up the .38. He twirled the cylinder, waited for it to stop, and then put the gun to his head.

"Bang!" Tigo said, and then he squeezed the

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trigger. Again the firing pin clicked on an empty chamber. Tigo let out his breath and put the gun down. "I thought I was dead that time," he said.

"You got a chick?" Danny asked. "What's her name?"

"Aw, you don't know her."

"Maybe I do," Danny said.

"Her name is Juana." Tigo watched him. "She's about five-two, got these brown eyes..."

"I think I know her," Danny said. He nodded. "Yeah, I think I know her."

"She's nice, ain't she?" Tigo asked. He leaned forward, as if Danny's answer was of great importance to him.

"Yeah she's nice," Danny said.

"Yeah. Hey maybe sometime we could..." Tigo cut himself short. He looked down at the gun, and his sudden enthusiasm seemed to ebb completely. "It's you turn," he said.

"Here goes nothing," Danny said. He twirled the cylinder, sucked in his breath, and then fired.

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The emptily click was loud in the stillness of the room.

"We better lower the odds. The boys won't like it if we..." He stopped himself again, and then reached for one of the cartridges on the table. He broke open the gun again, slipped in the second cartridge into the cylinder. "Now we got two cartridges in here," He paused. "You game?"

"That's... that's what we're here for, ain't it?" Danny said gently. "It's your spin."

Tigo lifted the gun. Idly, he began spinning the cylinder.

"You live on the next block, don't you?" Danny asked.

"Yeah."

"That's how come we never crossed paths, I guess. Also, I'm new on the scene."

"Yeah, well you know, you get hooked up with one club, that's the way it is."

"You like the guys on your club?"

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"They're okay." Tigo shrugged. "None of them really send me, but that's the club on my block, so what're you gonna do, huh?" His hand left the cylinder. It stopped spinning. He put the gun to his head.

"Wait!" Danny said.

Tigo looked puzzled. "What's the matter?"

"Nothing. I just wanted to say... I mean..." Danny frowned. "I don't dig too many of the guys on my club, either."

Tigo nodded. For a moment, their eyes locked. Then Tigo shrugged, and fired.

The empty click filled the basement room.

Tigo slid the gun across the table.

Danny hesitated an instant. He did not want to pick up the gun. He felt sure that this time he would shoot himself.

"Sometimes I think I'm turkey," he said to Tigo, surprised that his thoughts had found voice."I never told that to nobody. The guys on my club would laugh at me, I ever told them that."

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"Some things you got to keep to yourself. There ain't nobody you can trust in this world."

"There should be somebody you can trust," Danny said. "Hell, you can't tell nothing to your people. They don't understand."

"Sure, sure," Tigo said. "It ain't only that, though. Like sometimes... well, don't you wonder what you're doing stomping some guy in the street? Like ... who's the guy to you? What you got to beat him up for? 'Cause he messed with somebody else's girl?" Tigo shook his head. "It gets complicated sometimes."

"Yeah, but ..." Danny frowned again. "You got to stick with the club. Don't you?"

"Sure, sure ... hell yes." Again, their eyes locked.

"Well, here goes." Danny said. He lifted the gun, then twirled the cylinder. He studied the gun, wondering if one of the cartridges would roar from the barrel when he squeezed the trigger.

Then he fired.

Click.

"You got heart, Danny," Tigo said. He looked at

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the gun. He picked it up and broke it open.

"What you doing?" Danny asked.

"Another cartridge," Tigo said. "Six chambers, three cartridges. That makes it even money. You game?"

"It's your turn, you know."

"I know -- My spin," Tigo said wearily. He twirled the cylinder. "Here goes a good man," he said, and he put the revolver to his head and squeezed the trigger.

Click.

Danny smiled nervously. "No rest for the weary," he said. "But Jesus you've got the heart. I don't know if I can go through with it."

Sure, you can," Tigo assured him. "Listen, what's there to be afraid of?" He slid the gun across the table.

"We keep this up all night?" Danny asked.

"They said ... you know ... "

"Well, it ain't so bad. I mean, hell, we didn't have this operation, we wouldn'ta got a chance to talk, huh?" He grinned feebly.

"Yeah," Tigo said, his face splitting in a wide grin. "It ain't been so bad, huh?"

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He picked up the gun.

"We could say ... well ... like we kept shootin' an' nothing happened, so ..." Tigo shrugged. "Let's make this the last spin. Listen, they don't like it, they can take a flying leap, you know?"

"I don't think they'll like it. We're supposed to settle this for the clubs."

"Screw the clubs!" Tigo said. "Can't we pick our own ..." The word was hard coming. When it came, his eyes did not leave Danny's face. "... friends?"

"Sure we can," Danny said vehemently. "Sure we can! Why not?"

"The last spin," Tigo said. "Come on, the last spin."

"Game," Danny said. "Hey you know, I'm glad they got this idea. You know that? I'm actually glad!" He twirled the cylinder. "Look, you want to go on the lake this Sunday? I mean with your girl and mine? We could get two boats. Or even one if you want."

"Yeah, one boat," Tigo Said. "Hey, your girl'll like Juana, I mean it. She's a swell chick."

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The cylinder stopped. Danny put the gun to his head quickly.

"Here's to Sunday," he said. He grinned at Tigo, and Tigo grinned back, and then Danny fired.

The explosion rocked the small basement room, ripping away half of Danny's head, shattering his face. A small cry escaped Tigo's throat, and a look of incredulous shock knifed his eyes. Then he put his head on the table and began weeping.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Evan Hunter
Book: Manhattan Noir 2: The Classics
ISBN: 978-1933354576
Publisher: Akashic Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier

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